

John Paone, RHP, Virginia

2026 Stats: 5.85 ERA/60 IP/1.400 WHIP/69 K/23 BB/3.00 K:BB

6-3, 210

Metrics

FB: 93.0/22.4 IVB/8.8 HB/-5.21 VAA/33.3 AA/50% zone/0.2% usage/2230 rpm

SI: 93.6/9.2 IVB/17.4HB/-6.60VAA/5.83 ext/4.78 relH/15.1 AA/40.3% zone/45.4% usage/2330 rpm

SL: 82.9/0.2 IVB/-9.6 HB/-6.60 VAA/9.1 AA/34.6% zone/48.8% usage/2530 rpm

CH: 85.4/1.8 IVB/17.8 HB/-6.42 VAA/6.2 AA/22% zone/5.5% usage/1960 rpm

Write-up

Paone profiles as a sinker/slider reliever with one of the lower arm slots in the class, creating uncomfortable east-west angles that make both pitches play above their raw movement. Nearly 95% of his arsenal consisted of the sinker and slider, and while the approach lacked diversity, the combination consistently generated both weak contact and swing-and-miss. The slider is the carrying tool, pairing exceptional sweep with quality depth, while the sinker plays off it with heavy late armside movement. The delivery is short with a fast but stabby arm behind the body that falls behind his shoulders and whippy arm through release which causes some command problems but add to the deceptive angle game Paone plays. The biggest question moving forward is whether he can develop enough confidence in the changeup to keep left-handed hitters from sitting on the two-pitch mix. The ingredients for a professional bullpen arm are present, but a usable third offering would substantially raise the ceiling. The sinker is a quality professional offering, sitting in the low-to-mid 90s with plus armside run from an extremely low release height and arm slot. The movement profile creates severe horizontal approach angles, allowing the pitch to consistently run off barrels despite average vertical depth. Sometimes he cuts the SI and it goes deadzone but he is pretty consistent on average at getting ASR. Paone showed the ability to pound the zone with the pitch while attacking both sides of the plate, using the natural run to keep hitters from sitting dead red and boring into his armside. He turns over the ball incredibly, knocking the axis to 2:15 but getting it down to near 3:00 at times. 45/55 pitch

The slider is the better of the two pitches, a late spinner that gets both plus gloveside and depth from Paone's slot. He can throw it all over the zone, backdooring to LHH consistently and getting them to chase down and in while getting 47 whiffs from RHH this year, mostly on the outer half of the plate. The pitch occasionally backs up and misses up and armside with more of just gyro spin but when he gets it gloveside the pitch is squarely plus. Once he gets a more consistent feel, this is an elite pitch in the pros. It didn't generate enough whiff overall but that may be a product of the two pitch approach giving hitters 2 lanes to look at. 50/60 pitch